the arrow was probably shot by one of his troops); thereafter, he played a considerable role in clearing Afghan resistance from Sambhal and Lucknow. It wasn't just courage Ali Quli possessed, but also considerable flair. In Lucknow, being told mid-meal that 20,000 Afghans were marching at him, Ali Quli finished eating and began a game of chess before he rose to slay the enemy.

Badauni, who relates this anecdote with much admiration, describes Ali Quli's campaigns as 'a bright page in the annals of the time'. A later historian, Heinrich Blochmann, goes so far as to say that, after Bairam Khan, it is Ali Quli who deserves credit for 'the restoration of the Mughal Dynasty'.[60] And yet, soon after his impressive victory in Lucknow, the talk at Akbar's court turned from Ali Quli Shaibani's sangfroid to his fevered passion for Shahim Beg.

Shahim Beg was a *quorchi* – part of an elite class of soldiers at the Persian court, where his father held charge of the shah's camels, for which reason Abul Fazl refers to Shahim, sneeringly, as 'a camel driver's son'. Badauni tells the story with more sympathy. Shahim Beg, who had joined Humayun's court and remained in Akbar's, was a man of 'good looks, good disposition, and approved manners'; indeed, he embodied 'the beau ideal of the age', and Ali Quli had been smitten by him ever since Humayun's campaign for Hindustan began.

For a while, Ali Quli contented himself, in the manner of lovers, by writing moony poetry. 'Who else, as I for love of thee, lives such a weary life'?[61] But poetry, no matter how lovelorn, cannot take the beloved's place; and Ali Quli Shaibani was an intrepid man, after all. He sent a secret delegation to Delhi, where Shahim Beg was in attendance on Akbar, and smuggled his knight away.

Stories of Ali Quli's 'wonderful affection' began to spread: he would call Shahim 'my king', and wait on him 'like an ordinary servant', remain standing in his lover's presence. More: Shahim was a pious man, it seems, and to please him, Ali Quli 'became adorned with scrupulous regard for the Law' – presumably the sharia – even sending out officers to 'abolish all wanton and forbidden practices' in his camp.[62]

It may seem almost numbingly ironic to modern readers that a man embraced religious law in adoration of his gay lover, but there was clearly